

15 LEARNING LANGUAGES



*Without a knowledge of languages,
you feel as if you don't have a passport.*

Anton Pavlovich Chekhov

A different language is a different vision of life.

Federico Fellini

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **language:** mother tongue, first language, second language, foreign language
- **reasons for learning languages:** a must, prestige, entertainment, necessity, needs: social, personal, business, academic
- **learning and acquiring languages:** formal setting (school, private lessons), informal setting (at home) bilingual setting, multilingual and multicultural environment
- **English as a foreign language (EFL):** language learning proficiency levels (total beginner, false beginner, pre-intermediate, intermediate, upper-intermediate, advanced), to obtain a certificate, to take your finals
- **influential factors when learning a foreign language:** motivation (internal vs. external), attitude, aptitude (ability), age (young vs. adult learners), personality: introvert(ed) vs. extroverted (extraverted) learners, intelligence (linguistic intelligence), setting (place)
- **varieties of English:** British English, American English, Australian English, New Zealand English, Canadian English, South African English, Indian English, Caribbean English
- **the status of the English language:** lingua franca, the language of foreigners, immigrants, expatriates

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. What are your reasons for learning English?
2. What is difficult about learning a foreign language?
3. Why do some people find it difficult to speak foreign languages?
4. Which is more important when learning foreign languages? Intelligence or motivation?
5. What do you think is the best age to start learning a foreign language?
6. Can a foreign language be learned by watching television in that language?
7. How do you think small children "learn" their mother tongue?
8. Do you know anybody who speaks two mother tongues equally well?
9. What should foreign language learners do to be better in the language they are learning?
10. What is the purpose of taking the final exam ("maturita") in English?

C Simulation

If you were a secondary school teacher, what communication skills would you need to have to make your students interested in your subject? Consider:

- *verbal communication* (strength of the voice, intonation, pace of your speech, choice of words, pauses...)
- *non-verbal communication* (gestures, mime, eye contact, body posture, proximity to students)

D Role-play "FACEBOOKING"

You: You are very keen on chatting on Facebook with your friends. You think that it is a lot of fun to join different groups, exchange messages, update your profile and be in daily contact with your friends. However, your best friend is against using Facebook. *Try to persuade* him/her to join Facebook by telling him what he/she can use it for.

Your partner: You think that using Facebook is a very childish activity and that it is time-consuming. You don't want to join it because you want to protect your privacy. However, your best friend will try to persuade you to join it. *Give him/her your reasons* for not joining Facebook.

□ WRITING an essay (pisanie eseje)

Some people think that the Internet might be dangerous because one can easily become addicted to it. Others believe that it is not possible. In your essay (200–220 words), consider the problems that are connected with using the Internet. Also include:

- a title for your essay,
- express the general opinions of various people on the topic,
- *describe* the advantages and disadvantages of using the Internet and support your explanations with specific examples,
- summarise the ideas mentioned above and *express your own opinion*.

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

COMMON REASONS FOR LEARNING FOREIGN LANGUAGES

People learn **foreign languages** for **various** reasons. On the one hand, learning foreign languages can be a hobby for some people, or they might have professional, educational or social needs for learning them. On the other hand, their reasons may be connected to fashion and **prestige**. However, in this era of economic globalisation, it is becoming a **must** to speak a foreign language. People want to be able to communicate with the foreigners they meet when they travel or the ones they communicate with **via the Internet**. They also learn foreign languages (mostly English) in order to be able to understand foreign songs or read in a foreign language. **Mastering** a foreign language means being able to speak, write, understand speech and written texts in that language. **In some cases** people only **manage** to learn some of these **skills**. This might mean, for example, that somebody might be able to speak English but is not able to write in it **properly**. Surprisingly, there are some people who understand a foreign language but are not able to communicate in that language. Learning and using foreign languages makes our lives easier. It helps us communicate with people abroad, make new friends or meet business partners. It is pleasant and makes it easier to **get to know** other countries and new cultures when we speak a foreign language. It **increases** our **self-confidence** when we are able to read texts in a foreign language, understand songs and watch films without subtitles.

1. What common reasons are there for learning foreign languages?
2. What does mastering a foreign language mean?

LEARNING FOREIGN LANGUAGES AT SCHOOL

English, German, Spanish, French and other foreign languages have become a part of the **curriculum** at secondary schools. Russian has almost **disappeared** from our schools. However, it is **gradually** coming back. Many Slovak people still **have a passive knowledge of this language**. English, Spanish and German are the most learnt and popular languages in our country. Formal learning of foreign languages starts at primary schools and continues up to university. Some children learn English or another foreign language at a very early age. There are children who are **raised** in bilingual families. This means that they **acquire** two languages naturally and both of them are their **mother tongues**.

3. Which foreign languages are taught at secondary schools?
4. What background do bilingual children come from?

LANGUAGE EXAMS

Students at secondary schools usually **take a final exam** ("maturita") **in** one foreign language. The final language exam usually tests all language skills, such as listening **comprehension**, reading comprehension, writing and speaking. Many students take extra classes to **catch up** with others or learn more than they learn at school. Various language schools offer language-learning courses of different kinds. Language learners can **obtain** different language **certificates** for different proficiency levels. The English ones that are most **required** include TOEFL (Test of English as a Foreign Language), the Cambridge ESOL certificates (English for Speakers of Other Languages) or City & Guilds. The ESOL certificates include certificates in general, professional and academic English. They **provide qualifications** for learners of English. People usually take exams to **receive** these certificates to be able to study at a foreign university or get a good job.

5. What does the final exam "maturita" in English test?
6. What other language certificates can be obtained?

VARIETIES OF ENGLISH

Languages are **grouped into** language families. English belongs to the **Indo-European** language family, English is a **Germanic** Indo-European language, while Slovak is a **Slavic** Indo-European language. English is one of the most **widespread** languages in the world and it has many **varieties**. The most famous ones are British and American English. From around 1600, the English colonisation of North America **resulted** in the **creation** of a **distinct** American variety of English. Some "Americanisms" are in fact original British expressions that were **preserved** in the colonies. Spanish also **had an influence on** American English; Spanish words entered English through the **settlement** of the American West. French words (through Louisiana) and West African words (through the **slave trade**) also influenced American English. Today, American English is particularly **influential, due to** the USA's dominance of cinema, television, popular music, trade and technology (including the Internet). But there are many other varieties of English around the world, including for example Australian English, New Zealand English, Canadian English, South African English, Indian English and Caribbean English.

7. What are the most famous varieties of English?
8. What other languages influenced American English in the past?

ENGLISH – LINGUA FRANCA

English is one of the most widespread languages in the world. It is the *first language* (mother tongue) for most **inhabitants** of the United States of America, Canada, the United Kingdom, Ireland, Australia and New Zealand. There are a great number of countries where English is spoken as a *second language*, for example by **immigrants**. For tourists, who come to an English-speaking country, English is a *foreign language*. The English language

has become a **lingua franca** – a language of international communication in business, science and politics. English is used in many different countries in the world. These countries share the same language (or its **variations**), but every one of them has its own traditions and habits. English is used within many international organisations, **although** it is only one of the many official languages of the European Union. The role of the European Union has increased in the last few years. Although the EU has made travel, study and business easier, some small nations are afraid of losing their **identity** in a united Europe. Some politicians, on the other hand, **are calling for** a United States of Europe. Many people think that with so many **diverse** cultures this **seems unlikely to happen** in the near future.

9. What is the difference between English as a first language (mother tongue), a second language and a foreign language?
10. Why is English called a lingua franca?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

to acquire [ə'kwɪə(r)] – osvojiť si
although [ɔ:'lðəʊ] – hoci
to catch up – dohnať koho
certificate – certifikát
to call for – vyzývať
comprehension – porozumenie
creation – vytvorenie
curriculum [kə'ɪkjələm] – učebné osnovy
to disappear – zmiznúť
distinct – odlišný
diverse [daɪ'vɜ:s] – rozmanitý
due to [dju: tə] – kvôli
foreign language [fɔrən] – cudzí jazyk
Germanic [dʒɜ:mænik] – germánsky
gradually – postupne
to group into – zaradiť
to increase – zvýšiť
identity [aɪ'dentəti] – identita
Indo-European – Indoeurópsky
influential [ɪnflu'enʃl] – vplyvný
inhabitant – obyvateľ
immigrant – prisťahovalec
lingua franca [lɪŋgwə fræŋkə] – spoločný jazyk, lingua franca
to manage – dokázať
to master – zvládnuť
mother tongue [tʌŋ] – materinský jazyk
must – nutnosť, potreba
to obtain – získať
to preserve – zachovať

prestige [pre'sti:ʒ] – prestíž
properly – správne
to raise [reɪz] – vychovať
to require [rɪkwaɪə] – vyžadovať
to receive [rɪ'si:v] – prijať, dostať
to result – vyplynúť
second language – druhý jazyk
self-confidence – sebavedomie
settlement – osídlenie
skill – zručnosť
Slavic [sla:vɪk] – Slávsky
slave trade [sleɪv] – obchod s otrokmi
variety [və'raɪəti] – rozmanitosť, výber
various [veəriəs] – rôzny
variation [veəri'eɪʃn] – variácia
widespread – rozšírený

to get to know – spoznávať
to have an influence on – mať vplyv na
to have a passive knowledge of a language – ovládať jazyk pasívne
in some cases – v niektorých prípadoch
to provide qualifications [prə'vaɪd] – poskytnúť kvalifikácie
to seem unlikely to happen – zdať sa nepravdepodobné, že sa to stane
to take a final exam in – zložiť záverečnú skúšku z
via the Internet [vaɪə] – prostredníctvom, cez internet

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Which languages are spoken in the following countries?

a. England b. Wales c. Scotland d. Canada
e. the USA f. Mexico g. Ireland

**Task 2 Which are your biggest difficulties when learning English as a foreign language?
Read the list below and put a tick (✓) next to those that are a problem for you too.**

- I cannot spell some words in English.
- I have difficulties in understanding native speakers.
- I have to translate the things in my head before I say something.
- I do not understand tenses in English.
- I cannot remember new words.
- I think that my pronunciation is terrible.
- I cannot concentrate on long texts in English because I do not understand them.
- I am not able to write letters in English because I do not know how to write them.
- I do not speak in lessons because I am afraid that nobody will understand me.
- I think I have a very bad accent.

**Task 3 What other problems do you face when learning English? What can you do about them?
Ask your classmates to help you overcome your difficulties. Some ideas below can help you.**

listen to English songs – watch films in English – read books in English – record yourself – repeat words after hearing native speakers say them – use dictionaries – practise speaking with your classmates – practise speaking in front of a mirror – chat with somebody via the Internet – sing songs in English – speak English to yourself – learn three new words daily – go to an English-speaking country